27

Policymaking is siege-style assault

In mountaineering, the climbers choose from two strategies. In the siege-style assault, a large team establishes a base camp, which sets up the second camp and establishes the logistics for resupplying it, and so on. In the case of Mount Everest, there is a base camp at 5400 metres, camp 1 at 6100 metres, camp 2 at 6400 metres, camp 3 at 6800 metres and camp 4 at 8000 metres. Finally, from here, a few climbers try to get up to the top, which is at an altitude of 8848 metres. The siege-style assault is slow, expensive and reliable.

In an alpine-style assault, on the other hand, there is none of this preparation. One or two people try to walk up at the fastest possible pace. When the alpine-style assault works, the result is always remarkable. But it requires superhuman capabilities, and the probability of failure is high.

We think that the public policy process requires a siege-style assault. Every now and then, there are situations where an alpine-style assault yields some dramatic gains, but in time, these gains tend to be impermanent.

Example 32: The UK policy process on in vitro fertilization (IVF)

The world's first test-tube baby, Louise Brown, was born in the UK on 25 July 1978. There was a great deal of hostility to the concept of a test-tube baby at the time.